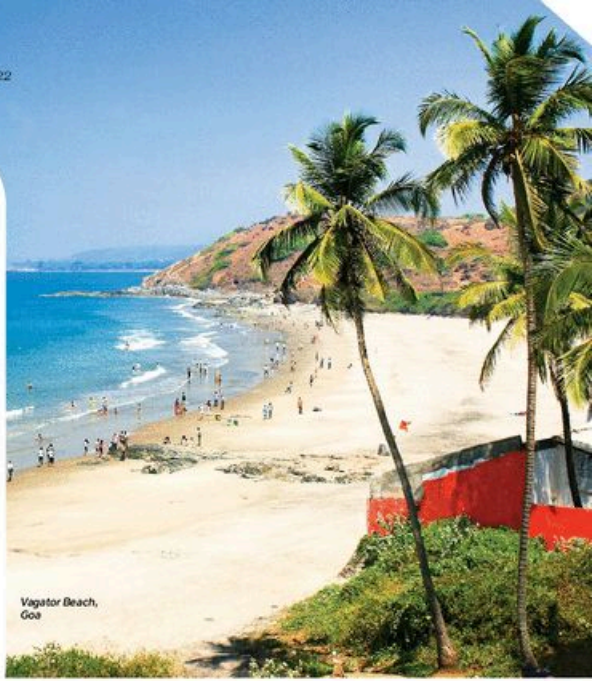
## TOP 5 LUXURY DESTINATIONS NEAR MUMBAI

### GOA

Goa somehow keeps growing. Seeing the north of the state being overrun by tourists and travellers, Goans began to shore up the south. Today, both sides of Goa offer travel experiences that are equally quintessential and restorative. There are today dozens of Goas, one for every kind of visitor. Anjuna with its hippie markets or the more laidback Mandrem are just two examples of the diverse beach life on offer, but Goa has a lot more than just sun and sand. While there are the Bhagwan Mahavir and Cotigao wildlife sanctuaries you can visit, Goa's thriving art scene also now affords thrills of its own.



Vagator Beach, Goa

### ALIBAUG

Alibaug was always only a three-hour drive from Mumbai, but thanks to the Ro-Ro car ferry service, you can now journey from Mazgaon to Mandwa in just 60 minutes. Even though it's beaches—Akhsi, Nagaon and Korlai, in particular—are hard to tire of, Alibaug does much to exceed the tag of 'coastal town'. Built during Shivaji's reign, the 17th century seaside Kolaba Fort still boasts of functioning freshwater wells. If your enthusiasm for history is matched by your love for art, Alibaug, you'll find, is home to several modern museums—The Guild, the Dashrath Patel Museum, the Karmarkar Museum.

### MATHERAN

If it's peace and quiet that you are after, there really could be no better destination than Matheran. After automobiles were banned inside this pretty hill station, it seemed to eliminate air and noise pollution altogether. During monsoons, waterfalls and wildflowers in the area spring to life, making your long walks here even more rewarding. Matheran is dotted with close to 40 look-out points, many of which provide jaw-dropping views of the valley below. Though Hanuman Langurs and Bonnet Macaques can be seen everywhere, it is the charm of Matheran's narrow-gauge train that never dies.

### MULSHI

While the Mulshi Dam and its picturesque surroundings are the main attraction here, there are plenty more options for activity that Mulshi offers. You could walk through the deep forests of nearby Sahyadri or visit the Dhangad and Koraigadh forts. From Valanewadi, only 6 km away from Mulshi, you will be able to witness the magnificence of the Mulshi Lake. The hills of Ratnagiri aren't very far either. Recently, Mulshi has also become home to several luxury resorts.

### MAHABALESHWAR

Given that Mahabaleshwar accounts for 85% of India's strawberry production, a visit to the town's strawberry farms is always a treat. Built on a plateau, the hill station has 25 look-out points, many of which offer grand views of waterfalls, the sunrise and sunset. You could sign up for a boat ride at the Venna Lake, one of Mahabaleshwar's major tourist attractions. The trekking trails here also promises staggering vistas, and with Panchgani nearby, paragliding becomes a ready possibility for visitors, too.